

**UNIT
10**

MODAL VERBS

UNIT 10 MODAL VERBS

26 UNDERSTANDING MODAL VERBS

Modal verbs are essential in English for expressing ability, permission, obligation, possibility, and probability. Unlike regular verbs, they do not follow the rules we use in tenses. They express certainty, necessity, ability, possibility, probability and similar expressions.

1. Modal Verbs for Expressing Ability: "Can", "Could" and "be able to"

1.1 Can

- **Meaning:** Expresses ability in the present or future.
- **Examples:**
- **Present ability:** I can solve complex math problems.
- **Future ability:** She can attend the seminar next week.

1.2 Could

- **Meaning:** Expresses ability in the past or polite requests.
- **Examples:**
- **Past ability:** When I was younger, I could climb mountains.
- **Polite request:** Could you help me with this assignment?"

Be Able To: Used for **present**, **past**, or **future** ability in more formal or specific contexts.

- **Examples:**
- **Present:** I am able to solve these problems easily.
- **Past:** She was able to complete the puzzle yesterday.
- **Future:** They will be able to visit us next week.

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with "can," "could," or the correct form of "be able to."

1. I _____ read English books fluently now.
2. When I was young, I _____ climb tall trees.
3. She _____ solve the riddle yesterday.
4. He _____ swim faster than anyone else in the class.
5. We _____ finish our homework before dinner today.
6. My grandfather _____ walk long distances when he was younger.
7. They _____ play cricket after school tomorrow.
8. I _____ help you with your project later this evening.

9. Despite the rain, she _____ get to school on time.
10. By next year, we _____ complete the entire course.

Exercise: 2

Complete the sentences with **can/can't/could/couldn't** + the following:

believe come hear run sleep wait

1. I'm afraid I _____ to your party next week.
2. When Hasan was 16, he _____ 100 meters in 11 seconds.
3. 'Are you in a hurry?' 'No, I've got plenty of time. I _____.
4. I don't feel good this morning. _____ last night.
5. Can you speak a little louder? I _____ you very well.
6. I was amazed when I heard the news. I _____ it.

Exercise: 1

Complete the answers to the questions with **was/were able to**

1. **A:** Did everybody escape from the fire?

B: Yes. The fire spread quickly, but everybody

2. **A:** Did you finish your work this afternoon?

B: Yes, there was nobody to disturb me, so I

3. **A:** Did you solve the problem?

B: Yes, we did. It wasn't easy, but we

4. **A:** Did the thief get away?

B: Yes. no one realised what was happening, and the thief

Roleplay Scenario

Situation: Two friends are planning their weekend activities. One friend suggests activities and the other responds with what they **can** or **could** do based on their abilities.

Example:

Friend 1: "Can you ride a bike to the park tomorrow?"

Friend 2: "Yes, I can. What about you?"

Monologue Topic

Topic: Talk about a skill you could do when you were younger but have forgotten now. Explain why it was important to you at that time.

2. Modal Verbs for Permission: "Can," "Could," "May," and "Might"

2.1 Asking for Permission

- **Can:** Informal. Example: "Can I borrow your pen?"
- **May:** Formal. Example: "May I leave early today?"
- **Could:** Polite and formal. Example: "Could I use your car?"
- **Might:** Hesitant. Example: "Might I join the meeting later?"

2.2 Giving Permission

- **Can:** Informal. Example: "You can take the day off."
- **May:** Formal. Example: "You may proceed with the task."

2.3 Refusing Permission

- **Cannot (Can't):** Informal. You can't go out tonight.
- **May not (Mayn't):** Polite refusal. You mayn't leave the room yet.

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with the correct modal verb.

1. _____ I join the class tomorrow?
2. You _____ borrow my laptop for the presentation.
3. He _____ not use his phone during the meeting.
4. _____ I leave early today?
5. You _____ not eat in the library.
6. She _____ take her umbrella if she needs it.
7. _____ I sit next to you during lunch?
8. They _____ not come to the party tonight.
9. We _____ borrow the books from the school library.
10. _____ we go to the park after school?

Monologue Topic

Topic: Talk about three rules or pieces of advice that students **must** follow in school and explain why they are important.

4. Modal Verbs for Possibility and Probability: "May" and "Might"

4.1 May

- **Meaning:** Possibility (50% chances).
- **Example:** "We may go to the park tomorrow."

4.2 Might

- **Meaning:** Possibility (30% chances).
- **Example:** "It might rain later today."

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with "may" or "might."

1. I _____ visit my cousins this weekend.
2. She _____ not attend the class tomorrow due to illness.
3. It _____ snow in the mountains tonight.
4. They _____ come to the party, but they haven't decided yet.
5. We _____ go hiking if the weather improves.
6. He _____ not be available for the meeting.
7. I _____ join the cricket team next year.
8. She _____ bake a cake for the event.
9. They _____ call us later to confirm the plan.
10. It _____ not be necessary to bring food for the picnic.

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UNDERSTANDING PAST MODALS FOR POSSIBILITY, ADVICE, AND REGRET

Past modals like "could have," "should have," "might have," and "may have" are used to talk about possibilities, advice, regrets, or missed opportunities in the past. They allow us to reflect on what could have happened, what someone should have done, or what might have been possible.

1. Could have + 3rd form (past participle)

- This means **something was possible** in the past, but **it didn't happen**.

Example:

"I **could have won** the race, but I was too tired."
(It was possible to win, but I didn't win.)

2. Couldn't have + 3rd form (past participle)

• This means **something was impossible** in the past. It **could not happen** no matter what.

Example:

"She **couldn't have known** the answer; she wasn't in class."
(It was impossible for her to know because she wasn't there.)

In short:

- **Could have** = Possible, but didn't happen
- **Couldn't have** = Impossible to happen

Examples (Using action verbs)

1. Police could have arrested us.
2. She could have fallen down.
3. It could have rained.
4. I couldn't have finished my homework without your help.
5. She couldn't have won the race without practising hard.

State Examples (Using 'been')

1. She could have been more careful.
2. The weather could have been better yesterday.
3. He could have been at the party, but he wasn't invited.
4. It couldn't have been John who broke the window; he was at school.
5. The test couldn't have been easier; everyone finished quickly!

Possession Examples (Using 'had')

1. I could have had more fun if I had gone to the picnic.
2. He could have had a better job if he had studied harder.
3. They could have had a great trip if the weather hadn't been bad.
4. They **couldn't have had** a better vacation.
5. I **couldn't have had** more fun at the party!

2. Should have + 3rd form

• **Meaning:** You were supposed to do something, but you didn't do it.

• **Example:** You should have studied for the test.
(This means you didn't study, but it was the right thing to do.)

Shouldn't have + 3rd form

• **Meaning:** You did something, but it was wrong or a mistake.

• **Example:** You shouldn't have eaten so much cake.
(This means you ate too much cake, and that was a bad idea.)

In short:

- **Should have** = You didn't do it, but it was good to do.
- **Shouldn't have** = You did it, but it was bad to do.

Examples:

1. She should have studied more for the test.
2. We should have left earlier to catch the train.
3. He should have told the truth instead of lying.
4. You shouldn't have interfered in my matter.
5. I shouldn't have missed my bus.

State Examples (Using 'been')

1. You should have been more patient with her.
2. The results should have been better if they had worked harder.
3. He should have been at the meeting on time.
4. You shouldn't have been so rude to your teacher.
5. The dog shouldn't have been outside in the rain.

Possession Examples (Using 'had')

1. I should have had a backup plan for the project.
2. They should have had enough food for everyone at the event.
3. She should have had more confidence during her presentation.
4. I **shouldn't have had** so much ice cream; now I have a stomachache.
5. She **shouldn't have had** her phone during class.

1. May/Might have + 3rd form (Past Participle)

Meaning:

- **May/Might have + 3rd form** is used when you are **not sure** if something happened in the past, but it was **possible**. **May have** expresses stronger possibility than **might have**.

Affirmative Examples:

1. She **may/might have forgotten** her homework at home.
2. They **may/might have seen** the new movie already.

Negative Examples:

1. He **may/might not have heard** the doorbell.
2. You **may/might not have understood** the instructions correctly.

2. May/Might have been

Meaning:

- **May/Might have been** is used when you think it's **possible** someone was **in a situation** or **had a feeling** in the past, but you're not certain. **May have been** expresses stronger possibility than **might have been**.

Affirmative Examples:

1. She **may/might have been** tired after the long trip.
2. The keys **may/might have been** on the table.

Negative Examples:

1. He **may/might not have been** ready for the test.
2. They **may/might not have been** at the party last night.

3. May/Might have had

Meaning:

- **May/Might have had** is used when you think someone **possibly had a possession** in the past, but you're not certain. **May have had** expresses stronger possibility than **might have had**.

Affirmative Examples:

1. You **may/might have had** more fun if you joined us.
2. She **may/might have had** a cold last week.

Negative Examples:

1. He **may/might not have had** enough money to buy the book.
2. They **may/might not have had** time to finish the project.

• Would Have + 3rd Form (Past Participle)

Meaning:

- We use "**would have + 3rd form**" to talk about something that **was possible to happen** in the past, but **didn't actually happen**. It's often used to imagine or express regret about past actions.

Affirmative Examples:

1. I **would have gone** to the party if I had not been sick.
2. She **would have finished** her homework if she had had more time.

Negative Examples:

1. They **wouldn't have missed** the bus if they had left earlier.
2. He **wouldn't have broken** the vase if he had been careful.

2. Would Have Been

Meaning:

- We use "**would have been**" to talk about a **state or condition** that was possible to exist in the past but **didn't**.

Affirmative Examples:

1. I **would have been** happy if you had visited me.
2. She **would have been** a great teacher if she had chosen that career.

Negative Examples:

1. They **wouldn't have been** tired if they had rested.
2. He **wouldn't have been** late if he had woken up early.

3. Would Have Had

Meaning:

- We use "**would have had**" to talk about something someone **possibly had** in the past, but **didn't**.

Affirmative Examples:

1. I **would have had** more fun if my friends had come to the picnic.
2. She **would have had** enough money to buy the dress if she had saved more.

Negative Examples:

1. We **wouldn't have had** any problems if we had followed the instructions.
2. He **wouldn't have had** a headache if he had drunk enough water.

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with the correct option: "**could have**," "**should have**," "**might have**," or "**may have**."

1. He _____ completed the assignment on time, but he procrastinated.
(could have/should have)
2. You _____ asked for help instead of struggling alone.
(should have/might have)
3. She _____ forgotten about the meeting; she has been so busy.
(might have/may have)
4. They _____ had a better outcome if they worked together.
(could have/should have)
5. We _____ been more prepared for the test.
(should have/could have)
6. He _____ taken the wrong bus, which is why he's late.
(might have/could have)
7. I _____ had a better grade if I had studied more.
(could have/should have)
8. You _____ been more polite to the guest.
(should have/may have)
9. They _____ gotten lost because they didn't have a map.
(might have/could have)

10. She _____ been upset because no one called her on her birthday.
(may have/might have)
11. I _____ joined the debate team, but I was too shy to try out.
(could have/might have)
12. They _____ been at the park; I saw them heading in that direction.
(might have/may have)
13. He _____ taken more notes during the lecture.
(should have/could have)
14. You _____ avoided the problem if you had been more careful.
(could have/should have)
15. She _____ had more success with the project if she had planned better. (could have/may have)

Exercise: 2

Rewrite the sentences using the correct past modal.

1. It's possible that she forgot her umbrella.

2. You didn't attend the meeting; it was important.

3. They didn't take the opportunity to participate.

4. He didn't tell the truth, but he should have.

5. I'm not sure, but he was probably stuck in traffic.

6. She didn't save her work, and now it's lost.

7. It's possible that they left their bag at the café.

8. He didn't study for the test, but he had the time.

9. I'm not sure, but she was probably tired after the long trip.

10. They didn't fix the machine, and now it's broken.

11. It's possible that he forgot about the appointment.

12. She didn't take the chance to speak at the event.

13. It's likely that they were late because of the traffic jam.

14. He didn't tell anyone about his idea, but it was a good one.

15. It's possible that they misunderstood the instructions.

Exercise: 3

Complete the sentences using might not have ... or couldn't have ...

1. **A:** I was surprised Hania wasn't at the meeting. Perhaps she didn't know about it.

B: She _____ about it.

2. **A:** I wonder why Tom didn't come to the party. Perhaps he didn't want to come.

B: He _____ come.

3. **A:** I wonder how the fire started. Was it an accident?

B: No, the police say it _____ an accident. It was deliberate.

4. **A:** Ali says he needs to see you. He tried to find you yesterday.

B: Well, he _____ very hard. I was in my office all day.

5. **A:** Are you sure The man you spoke to was American ?

B: No, I'm not sure. He _____

Exercise: 4

For each situation, write a sentence with should or shouldn't + one of the following:

go away for a few days stay up so late look for another job
put some pictures on the walls take a picture worry so much

1. Sarah needs a change.

She should go away for a few days.

2. Your salary is very low.

You _____

3. Jack always finds it hard to get up.

He _____

4. What a beautiful view!

You _____

5. Sofia is always anxious.

She _____

6. Hasan's room isn't very nice.

He _____

Exercise: 5

Complete the sentences. Use should or should have + the verb in brackets.

1. You look tired. You *should go* to bed. (go)

2. You missed a great party last night. *You should have come.* (come)

3. I'm in a difficult position. What do you think I _____
_____ now? (do)

4. I'm sorry that I didn't take your advice. I _____
what you said. (do)

5. We lost the game, but we were the better team. We _____
_____ (win)

6. We don't see you enough. You _____ and see
us more often. (come)

7. We went the wrong way and got lost. We _____
right, not left. (turn)

8. My exam results weren't good. I _____ better. (do)

Exercise: 6

Read the situations and write sentences with should / should have / shouldn't / shouldn't have.

1. I'm feeling sick. I ate too much.

I shouldn't have eaten so much.

2. When we got to the restaurant, there were no free tables. We hadn't reserved one.

We _____

3. Sofia told me her address, but I didn't write it down. Now I can't remember the house number.

I _____

4. The shop is open every day from 8.30. It is 9 o'clock now, but the shop isn't open yet.

It _____

5. I was looking at my phone. I wasn't looking where I was going. I walked into a wall.

I _____

6. Sofia is driving. The speed limit is 30 miles an hour, but Sofia is doing 50.

She _____

7. I wasn't feeling well yesterday, but I went to work. That was a mistake. Now I feel worse.

I _____

8. Tomorrow there is a football match between Team A and Team B. Team A are much better.

Team A _____

9. I was driving. The car in front stopped suddenly and I drove into it. It wasn't my fault.

The driver in front _____

Exercise: 7

Complete the second sentence so that it means the same as the first.

1. 'It would be a good idea to eat more fruit,' the doctor said to me.

The doctor recommended that I should eat more fruit.

2. 'You really must stay a little longer,' she said to me.

She insisted that I _____

3. 'Why don't you visit the museum after lunch?' I said to them.

I suggested that _____

4. 'You must pay the rent by Friday,' the landlord said to us.

The landlord demanded that _____

5. 'Let's go to the cinema,' Hasan said to me.

Hasan suggested that _____

Exercise: 8

Fill in the blanks with "would have," "would have been," or "would have had."

1. If you had asked earlier, I _____ helped you.

2. She _____ happier if she had passed her exam.

3. They _____ more time to prepare if the event had been postponed.

4. He _____ at the party if he had finished his work on time.

5. The cake _____ better if we had used fresh ingredients.

6. I _____ more fun on the trip if it hadn't rained all day.

7. We _____ a great view of the sunset if we had arrived earlier.

8. You _____ the opportunity to win if you had entered the contest.

9. The test _____ easier if I had studied harder.

10. She _____ more confident if she had practised her speech.

Exercise: 8

Rewrite the sentences using "would have," "would have been," or "would have had."

1. He didn't study for the test, so he didn't pass.
2. They weren't at the concert because they didn't buy tickets.
3. I didn't go to the event, but it sounds like it was great.
4. She didn't bring an umbrella, so she got wet in the rain.
5. We didn't reach on time because the bus was late.
6. The room wasn't decorated, so the party felt plain.
7. If she had applied earlier, she could have gotten the scholarship.
8. They didn't practise, so their performance wasn't very good.
9. I wasn't aware of the meeting, so I missed it.
10. The team didn't work together, so they lost the competition.